



RECRUITMENT SCAM

How it came to light and the current status of vigilance probe:

2003: BPSC conducted first limited competitive examination for selection of Class III government officials as deputy collectors.

MAY 2005: BPSC declared 184 candidates successful.

DECEMBER 2005: Chief Minister Nitish Kumar ordered a vigilance probe and stalled the training and posting of these candidates.

DECEMBER 2005: BPSC chairman and eight others arrested and sent to judicial custody.

FEBRUARY 2006: Former BPSC chairperson Razia Tabassum surrendered and sent to judicial custody.

MAY 2008: Vigilance recommended scrapping of the examination results. It filed charge-sheets against 104 people.

BROUGHT TO BOOK: Former BPSC chairpersons Ramsinghasan (left) and Tabassum being taken into custody (both are out on bail now)



checking gave them a greater control over allocation of marks," he adds. Interestingly, one of the successful candidates is Bijendra Kumar, who is a data entry operator with BPSC. His primary responsibility was to monitor the database.

According to the charge-sheet, BPSC officials allowed some candidates to erase their wrong responses (marked in pencil) and replace them with the correct answers. Also, many successful candidates were found to have submitted forged caste certificates. The bureau had gathered evidences about the irregularities by December 30, 2005. It arrested the then BPSC chairman Ramsinghasan Singh and member BPSC Shivbalak Choudhary. Another member Deonandan Sharma surrendered later. Seven other officials—deputy secretary Sayed Masoom Ali, assistant secretary Tej Narayan Singh, information officer Sanjiv Kumar, two programme analysts Vijay Kumar and Bhanu Pratap, and two section officers, Kamta Prasad and Ratnesh Kumar Sinha—were also arrested on charges of forgery, cheating and corruption. In February 2006, Ramsinghasan's predecessor Razia Tabassum surrendered in the court of special vigilance judge. While the two former chairpersons have already retired, the two BPSC members have been suspended.

The bureau has found that a veterinary doctor, Subodh Kumar was one of the major cogs in the scam machine. "Subodh, a middleman, is considered close to Choudhary and had even arranged loans for few applicants—money that was obviously used for bribing," says Neelmani. Incidentally, before taking over as member, BPSC, Choudhary was director in the Animal Husbandry Department. A raid at Subodh's residence had yielded thousands of forged MBBS certificates, besides details about other serious irregularities in other competitive examinations held by BPSC.

The limited examination held for junior officers in 2003 was the first such competitive examination held in Bihar. While the court deliberates over the candidates' fate, there is no similar opportunity in sight for other wannabe babus among junior officials in the state. BPSC is extremely unlikely to go for anything limited again. ■